

FARMING



BY CULTIVATING CROPS and raising animals, farms produce food and other products. Ten per cent of people in developed nations, and 60 per cent in developing countries, make their living from farming. In the West, technology makes the land highly productive, producing abundant, cheap food, and requiring fewer workers. In developing countries, farms have much lower yields because the soil or climate are often unsuitable for agriculture, and farmers, unable to afford new machines and chemicals, must rely on labour-intensive methods.

Crops

Ancient farmers bred crop plants by collecting and sowing the seed from the healthiest wild plants: the first cultivated crop was probably a kind of wheat. Today's major food crops are wheat, rice, maize (corn), and potatoes; major non-food crops include cotton and tobacco. The types and quantities of crops a farmer can grow are determined by soil and climate.

Rice

Rice is a cereal, and the main food of half the world's people. Asia produces 90 per cent of the world's crop. Plants are grown in warm climates, usually on flooded "paddy" fields. Rice is a labour-intensive crop, which means most of the work is done by people, rather than machines.

Rice seedlings



Sorting the maize harvest, Ghana



Cotton bolls (seed pods)



Cotton

The cotton crop provides fibres and oil. The main producers of the world's cotton are China and the USA.

Terraced fields

Harvesting rice by hand



Paddy field, China

Plants are cut down, and left in bundles to dry out.

Maize

Maize is a kind of grass. There are many varieties, which can be ground into flour, eaten as a vegetable, made into oil, or used as animal feed. Maize is a major crop in the United States, Brazil, southern Africa, and parts of Asia.



Maize

Types of farms

In the developed world, mixed farms were once common; farmers grew a few different crops and kept some livestock. Today's technology makes it advantageous for farms to specialize, raising just one kind of crop or animal with very high output. Such farming is big business. Some farmers, concerned by the possible effects on the environment, have

changed to organic farming, where artificial fertilizers and pesticides are not used.



Shepherd shakes seed pods from a tree to feed sheep.

Subsistence farming

Subsistence farmers produce only enough to feed their household, with little or no surplus to sell. This is more common in developing nations where many farmers cannot afford the chemicals or machinery that would increase their yield, and rely on centuries-old farming methods.

Subsistence farming, Kenya

Commercial farming

Commercial farmers farm animals and crops intensively. They aim for a high yield and sell their produce for profit. In many countries, farmers produce too much food. When surplus crops and animals force food prices down, damaging the food industry, governments pay farmers to grow less.



Cattle fair, Argentina

Livestock

Farmers rear livestock (animals) for meat, milk, eggs, skins, and wool. In some cases, livestock is reared intensively, with many animals kept indoors in artificial conditions to encourage fast growth. By contrast "free-range" animals are reared outside; they live more like their wild counterparts, but their products are more costly.



Sheep's milk



Butter, from cow's milk

Farmers kept goats and sheep for milk long before cattle.



Cheese, from goat's milk

Dairy farming

Dairy farming is the breeding of animals for their milk and milk products. Cows are the main dairy animals, producing 10 to 15 litres (2.6 to 4 US gallons) of milk a day on average. Sheep and goats are also raised for their milk.

Sheep

The versatile sheep produces meat, wool, and milk. Sheep do not need such rich pasture as cattle: they can survive on poor quality land, and in dry or cold climates.

Sheep-shearing takes place in late spring.

